

Strategic Advisory Group (SAG) Meeting

Participants Organizations: NDRCS/VSO, IFRC, IOM, Habitat for Humanity, DFID, SDC, Build Change, JICA, CRS, NSET, SCF

1. Introduction

The meeting was started by Suzana Paklar (IOM) who welcomed everyone and introduced the new IOM Chief of Mission, Paul Norton, who took on the role in July this year but has been working in Nepal for several years. Suzana Paklar also introduced the new national coordinator of the HRRP, Loren Lockwood. IOM thanked CRS for providing the national coordinator. Loren Lockwood stressed that CRS contributing the national coordinator to the HRRP represents what he hopes to reinvigorate in terms of the HRRP being a platform, and all partners being party to supporting the platform. Loren also highlighted that the budget is quite tight for the HRRP so any support from partners would be greatly appreciated. Loren also had a special welcome for NSET, highlighting the need to reinvigorate and strengthen the links with NSET for technical coordination.

2. District Coordination

Recognising that there have been challenges with district coordination, in particular due to differences in coordination capacity across the districts, several practical steps were proposed by the HRRP team to address this:

- Develop set of five aims / objectives for district coordination to support district coordinators to focus and prioritise their work, and to demonstrate at national level the impact and value of district coordination
- A stocktake will be done internally within the HRRP for each district and a roadmap will be prepared for the next steps to improve coordination. Meetings will also be conducted in each district with all relevant actors to look at the broader coordination strategy. This will also be an opportunity to look at how the HRRP can best work in that district, e.g. is physical integration best, or is there a better option.
- Hoping to reinvigorate the hub coordinator role and look to hold smaller hub workshops where district teams can have a chance to share and benefit from each other's experiences.
- The hiring process is ongoing to fill gaps in district coordination and hub coordination.
- HRRP has secured support from the Global Shelter Cluster so that GSC team members who will be in Nepal for a training at the beginning of November will also conduct a one day intensive coaching session with the HRRP coordination teams.

DFID: Where it is working well, HRRP district coordination is making a really valuable contribution, for example on enrolment. There are examples, and knowledge within the platform of what good coordination looks like and there need to be action orientated steps to build on this, especially as reconstruction is set to start to move faster following the festivals. Generally speaking the NRA is still not very strong at district level, especially where it was originally sub-regional and then moved to district offices. HRRP district coordination need to support what the government is trying to achieve in order to be truly effective. Suggested that if there is a good hub coordinator in place already then continue but based on previous experience would suggest that it might be inefficient and may be better to have one district coordinator in a group as the lead and to provide additional capacity building support.

Build Change: It would be good to know the overall timeframe for the new HRRP phase. This gives an idea of how much effort to put into different aspects and what to prioritise.

Loren: Current phase of funding is until end of February, if it is deemed useful and funds are found then will continue but important to turn it around over the next few months to demonstrate value.

HfH: Having relatively recently taken on district coordination in Kavre, HfH have found that often the district coordination team are preparing reports for the LDO and CDO, which may not necessarily be the fundamental role of the HRRP. But it is clear that the government offices at district level don't have capacity to do IM themselves so they

are drawing on HRRP for this and this may be an argument for extended funding for the HRRP. Need to define the aims of HRRP district coordination and how they are measured. Important to know this so that at the end of February it is possible to measure how it has performed.

Loren: SAG's support will be required to define goals to be achieved by the end of February.

CRS: Fundraising needs to start now to ensure that there is no lag. The SAG members need to take this on more actively, maybe as a smaller working group. Lurching from short term funding to short term funding prevents longer term, more concrete goals from being developed and achieved. Need to consider what the value added for district and national government is of the HRRP and what they want from it. Also important to show that the HRRP is not only funded by DFID. Some partners are contributing a lot and it would be good to get this information and present it visually to show what resources organisations are investing in this. This should make the platform more attractive to DFID and other donors.

DFID: The blip in funding between HRRP phase 1 and 2 occurred because the DFID overall programme took time to get approval from the government. The platform is vulnerable if there is only one donor and the donor base needs to be broadened. If there are some efficiencies (e.g. not having hub coordinators) DFID are comfortable with allowing a no cost extension if there are still funds available.

IOM: The second phase of the HRRP includes two more internal reviews, the first of which needs to start next month. Preparation for this needs to start as soon as possible, and SAG members need to provide input as to what is expected from this. This could also feed into developing the funding strategy.

DFID: expecting a step increase in coordination linked to delivery and as such are not sure that conducting another internal review at this point is effective use of time. The review session conducted in March / April was time consuming and the context was very different. It would be better to focus on delivering key pieces of work and activities.

Build Change: It may be useful to revisit and update the 4W as the context has changed and the data needs are quite different now.

IFRC: There are concerns in several districts because there households moving ahead beyond the first tranche level without the right paperwork because the DUDBC engineers have given them a verbal go ahead. It is still not even clear how many tranches there will be. It's also not clear if there is money to support retrofitting and what the actual level of funding available for the grants is.

DFID: Expectation is that the grants will be fully funded across all enrolled households.

Loren: A new hub coordinator, seconded by SDC, will be arriving next week and joining the HRRP team.

3. Information Management

The HRRP IM team now has two IM officers embedded in the NRA (working full time in the MIS team, under the Chief of Communication and Information), which is a very positive step, but there is still a lot of work to do to make IM worthwhile in the NRA at national level. The main areas which the HRRP IM team are working to improve are:

- Data sharing – this has been very challenging to date and it is hoped that it can be improved. The HRRP IM team are working on the development of the NRA IM strategy, and have proposed a list of data sets that could be made public. The HRRP IM team are also supporting with the development of front end interactive visuals to present the data for sharing.
- Streamlining of data collection – it has been challenging for partners to be requested to submit data via a number of different matrices. The HRRP IM team are trying to streamline this and are working with the NRA to have one system, and one matrix which would all be managed by NRA. Related to this the HRRP IM team has almost completed the development of a project proposal management and monitoring system for the

NRA. POs will be provided with login details for this online system and will be able to enter monitoring data through the system.

- There remains a question around how to make IM worthwhile in the NRA? Both inwards in terms of how the NRA can work more efficiently on IM, and outwards in terms of how to maintain the 4W to still feed into general coordination, especially around technical assistance, with the majority of HRRP IM capacity now seconded fully into the NRA.

HfH: Seems simpler for IM in the sense that there are products that partners need, if these are published by the NRA then the HRRP no longer needs to publish them. There is a need to define the objectives and goals for IM and to understand what the partners needs from IM. District coordination and IM are very function orientated and therefore different to national coordination which is more topic and representation orientated, where the HRRP has an influencing aspect and acts as the collective voice of partners. Maybe it is better to pick a few topics to focus on, for example can the HRRP come up with things to help move ahead critical path items such as tranche payment guidelines?

Loren: IM can be misinterpreted as reporting, but actually it is a vital tool for coordination and so can't just be viewed in terms of what products partners need. There are lots of details in the data collection that are very useful for district, and national, level coordination and this has to be taken into account. Also, lots of the NRA products and data are different to what HRRP partners need. To fully move IM to the NRA all the elements required by partners and for coordination to operate need to be gathered and produced by the NRA. At the moment there is a need for increased IM capacity within the HRRP so that the 4W's can continue.

4. Technical Assistance and Coverage

Loren: Currently the definition of TA not strong enough and it is difficult to determine what coverage levels really are in the districts.

JICA: currently supporting technical assistance in Gorkha and Sindhupalchowk and there are POs supporting house construction in these districts and JICA have found differences in the level of cash or other support being provided. JICA would appreciate HRRP support to resolve these issues in the district. Loren informed that the best approach is to contact the district coordination teams directly as they are experienced in resolving issues like this through smaller meetings at district level.

NSET: The National Reconstruction Technology Centre (NRTC), which NSET is in the process of establishing, has the objective of looking at the technical standards for housing to see what the solutions are for specific areas with difference construction practices, how people are using new construction materials, doing research, etc. NSET are still trying to work out where the NRTC fits and how it functions with government and it is thought that the HRRP will be a key actor to coordinate this also. This is a big task and will require a team to work on this, and support the relevant government entities on this.

DFID: In terms of technical materials is there is a lot available from DUDBC and who is responsible for developing guidelines for retrofitting?

NSET: Lots of different organisations are preparing technical materials but there are lots of problems that need more in depth studies. The NRA and CL-PIU are responsible for retrofitting guidelines but there is no technical group there yet. The NRA have requested support from partners to bring technical solutions.

Build Change: Would there be a TWG in the NRTC? It could be good to set up and invite the government rather than waiting for the government to establish working groups. Everything is already starting to happen in the field and there is an urgency about getting started now. It may be good to escalate the NRTC by being more closely linked with the HRRP.

SCF: informed that they are planning to establish a technical resource centre in Kavre and Sindhupalchowk.

Loren: Planning to hold technical update sessions to catch up on all topics, it would be good to get SAG advice on whether to have a general one for all topics or specific ones for each topic. From these, can form TWGs if needed, or we can encourage ppl to work in the NRTC, etc. Some topics are more urgent than others.

5. General Coordination

Loren: Intending to engage a translator so that all documents, emails, meeting minutes, etc. can be sent out in both languages and documents coming in can be translated for partners. Also intending to have a weekly email going out to partners with updates and information from the HRRP.

Build Change: Recommend to have a general announcement about relaunch of HRRP and new coordinator and to check who is still around as there will have been turnover during the HRRP's transition from 1st to 2nd phase. Also need to decide how the HRRP will manage that the NRA doesn't want anything shared before it is the final version which leaves everyone in the dark until the final version is released. As a platform the HRRP needs to level out the information that everyone has, currently there are different levels available to different partners. Will there be times that the HRRP can publish things before the NRA?

SDC: there may be a risk to having HRRP teams integrated in the NRA in that it may make everything slow. Suggested that SAG meetings should have an agenda that is shared in advance and maybe even ideas and suggestions could be collected in advance so meetings can be kept to one hour. Also recommended that this is not a moment for brainstorming but to get things done and that focusing on districts is probably a good option for this.

DFID: what is the status of the NRA ops room?

Loren: It is not clear but understanding is there is space available and would like to have HRRP team sitting there.

6. SAG Membership

It was proposed to invite the Shelter Cluster to be a member of the SAG so that SC is better integrated with strategic HRRP discussions, and there were no objections to this.

There was discussion around whether or not the Government should be represented in the SAG. CRS suggested that maybe one SAG meeting each month could be with Government and one could be without. Loren suggested that it may be better to see how having greater HRRP presence in the NRA over the next 2/3 weeks works and then see if it is necessary to restart the HRRP NRA Friday afternoon meetings. All suggested that the Friday meetings had been a good chance to raise issues and concerns with the NRA but it was hard to prepare sufficiently and the outcomes of the meetings were not fed back to the wider group. IFRC suggested that Loren start with one on one meetings with key NRA people and then only bring SAG members for major issues. CRS suggested that it may be useful to look into hiring a Nepali counterpart for the HRRP national coordinator role, and highlighted that if this is deemed necessary by the SAG members it would need to be prioritised as it would take time to find the right candidate.

7. Action Points

- Lorraine (CRS) and Suzana (IOM) to lead establishment of funding working group within SAG
- Jessica (Build Change) and Ranjan and Hima (NSET) to support with developing plan for technical update sessions
- Suzana (IOM) to share Logframe and budget for HRRP phase 2 with SAG members
- Loren (HRRP) to invite Shelter Cluster to become SAG member and work to increase representation of local NGOs in the SAG
- Dream (HRRP) to prepare the Introduction/Briefing Pack for partners and share with SAG members for review
- Loren (HRRP) to share the work plan and time frame for the next 6 months with SAG members for review